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Karimnagar govt officials learn sign language to bridge communication gap

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Hyderabad: In a move towards inclusive governance, govt officials in Karimnagar district are now learning Indian Sign Language (ISL) to better interact with citizens who are speech and hearing impaired.

The initiative, which covers staff across various departments, aims to equip them with basic sign language skills to make public services more accessible. From common greetings and numbers to understanding days, months, and familial terms, the officials are being trained to hold simple conversations and ensure effective communication.

"I've learnt the basics, but there's a long way to go. When speech- and hearing-impaired citizens approach us, they often come with someone to interpret. But when we understand them directly, it builds trust and ensures clarity," Karimnagar municipal commissioner and IAS officer, Praful Desai told TOI.

This training, Desai pointed out, is especially useful during public grievance redressal sessions like Prajavani. "It's about meeting them on their terms, not the other way around," he added.

District collector Pamela Satpathy, who is also part of the training, said, "As public servants, it's our responsibility to understand the needs of every section of society. Learning sign language is one way to ensure that no one is left behind when it comes to accessing govt schemes and benefits."

The sessions, conducted by two trainers from an NGO, are being organised by Dr Marri Chenna Reddy Human Resource Development (MCRHRD) Institute. According to regional training manager and district youth officer M Venkata Rambabu, around 100 officials are attending the sessions daily, split into two batches.

Apart from conversational basics, the participants have also learnt to sign the national anthem.